

RINSE. WASH. REPEAT.



A NO BULLSHIT, COMPLETE GUIDE TO STARTING YOUR FITNESS JOURNEY

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REALITY CHECK

You're not lazy – You're overwhelmed.

We constantly consume and are overrun with information. The thing is, none of it is actually made for *you*. We open social media and see crazy workouts, perfect meal preps, insane transformations, and end up feeling like we're already behind.

The truth is, you don't need to workout everyday, eat perfectly, or say no to going out. At the end of the day you don't even need to be ready to start-- you just need to start, period.

So what actually gets results?

The honest answer-- the boring stuff. Rinse. Wash. Repeat. That's the name of the game. That's exactly where most people mess up; chasing *intensity* over *consistency*.

What this guide will do is untie the messy knot. I am going to break down every aspect of starting your fitness journey so that by the time you're done reading, you'll feel confident enough to really get going.

If you're feeling

- Overwhelmed
- Confused
- Intimidated

Good. Keep reading.

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What Actually Matters

Once you strip away all of the background noise, real results come down to 4 simple pillars.

PILLAR	PURPOSE
Training	Creates the stimulus
Nutrition	Fuels adaptation
Recovery	Allows adaptation
Consistency	Makes it all happen

Worksheet

Rate Yourself:

Training ____/10

Nutrition ____/10

Recovery ____/10

Consistency ____/10

Which area needs the most focus?

Your Starting Point

Before we really start, let's figure out where the starting line even is. This section is going to walk you through a few small guidelines to get us moving in the right direction.

1. How to set a realistic goal

Everyone has a some goal for their training. Some emotional *why*.

The problem with goals, though, is that people tend to set goals that are either a) very longterm or b) not measurable.

When you set a longterm goal, something like "I want to lose 100 pounds" it can feel discouraging if that's the only scope that you view your goals in.

As for measurability, people like to set goals like “I want to look better” or “I want to feel better”. While those are fantastic goals, they don’t have any unit of measurement to them, and progress can get lost in the grey area.

When you set goals, think of something specific, measurable, realistic, and timed.

Worksheet

My goal:

Why it matters:

Target date:

How will I measure success?

2. How to assess where you're currently at

Here, we're uncovering the obstacles you're going to have to face. Be honest.

How many days can I train?

- ☐ 2
- ☐ 3
- ☐ 4
- ☐ 5+

Have I trained before?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

Biggest obstacle:

- ☐ Time
- ☐ Confidence
- ☐ Nutrition
- ☐ Knowledge
- ☐ Consistency
- ☐ Other _____

Do I really truly know what it means to fuel my body with proper foods?

☐ Yes

☐ No

☐ Some, but I need put more effort to learn more

What active am I outside of the gym?

☐ Very active (lots of movement)

☐ Somewhat active (Some movement)

☐ Not active (Mostly sedentary)

That's it. No judgement of yourself – just awareness. That's why it's a starting point.

The plan you make should match *your* current lifestyle, not someone elses. This is chapter one, so don't try to jump into the routine of someone in chapter nine.

3. What NOT to worry about yet

Ignore These For Now:

- Perfect workout split
- Perfect macros
- Supplements
- What influencers are doing
- Being perfect

Focus On These Instead:

- Showing up
- Learning
- Building habits
- Consistency

The bottom line is this: you don't need a perfect plan. You need a starting point. Set a goal for yourself, be honest with where you're at, and don't worry about all of the finite things yet. All of the details come later.

The Training Plan

After answering the following questions, find your respective training plan. These are just examples, so don't feel like they are the only options!

Step 1

Choose:

- ☐ 3 days
- ☐ 4 days

Step 2

Choose:

- ☐ Gym
- ☐ Home

Step 3

Commit for 8 weeks

(Feel free to skim this section as it is very repetitive!)

3 Day Split – Gym Access

Day 1: Lower

Exercise	Sets	Reps
Squat variation	2-3	8-12
Lunge variation	2-3	8-12
Leg extension	2-3	8-12
Leg curl	2-3	8-12

Day 2: Upper

Exercise	Sets	Reps
Lat pulldowns	2-3	8-12
Incline DB raises	2-3	8-12
Lateral raises	2-3	8-12
Bicep curls	2-3	8-12
Tricep pushdowns	2-3	8-12

Day 3: Full

Exercise	Sets	Reps
Roman deadlifts	2-3	8-12
Closegrip cable rows	2-3	8-12
Goblet squats	2-3	8-12
Shoulder press	2-3	8-12

3 Day Split – Home

Day 1: Lower

Exercise	Sets	Reps
Bodyweight squats	2-3	8-12
Bulgarian split squats	2-3	8-12
Reverse lunges	2-3	8-12
Glute Bridges	2-3	8-12

Day 2:Upper

Exercise	Sets	Reps
Pushups (modification allowed)	2-3	8-12
Bentover backpack rows	2-3	8-12
Tricep dips	2-3	8-12
Pike pushups	2-3	8-12

Day 3: Full

Exercise	Sets	Reps
Sumo squats	2-3	8-12
Superman raises	2-3	8-12
Shoulder tap plank	2-3	8-12
Hollow body hold	2-3	8-12

4 Day Split – Gym Access

Day 1: Lower 1

Exercise	Sets	Reps
Squat variation	2-3	8-12
Bulgarian split squats	2-3	8-12
Walking lunges	2-3	8-12
Leg extension	2-3	8-12

Day 2: Upper 1

Exercise	Sets	Reps
Incline DB press	2-3	8-12
Arnold press	2-3	8-12
Overhead tricep extensions	2-3	8-12
Front raises	2-3	8-12
Tricep pushdowns	2-3	8-12

Day 3: Lower 2

Exercise	Sets	Reps
Hip thrust	2-3	8-12
Roman deadlift	2-3	8-12
Back extensions	2-3	8-12
Leg curl	2-3	8-12

Day 4: Upper 2

Exercise	Sets	Reps
Lat pulldowns	2-3	8-12
Seated cable rows	2-3	8-12
Cable bicep curls	2-3	8-12
Cable pullovers	2-3	8-12
Hammer curls	2-3	8-12

4 Day Split – Home

Day 1: Lower 1

Exercise	Sets	Reps
Bodyweight squats	2-3	8-12
Forward lunges	2-3	8-12
Bulgarian split squats	2-3	8-12
Calf raises	2-3	8-12

Day 2: Upper 1

Exercise	Sets	Reps
Widegrip pushups	2-3	8-12
Tricep dips	2-3	8-12
Pike pushups	2-3	8-12
Tricep pushups	2-3	8-12

Day 3: Lower 2

Exercise	Sets	Reps
Reverse lunges	2-3	8-12
Glute bridges	2-3	8-12
Sliding leg curls	2-3	8-12
Single leg roman deadlifts	2-3	8-12

Day 4: Upper 2

Exercise	Sets	Reps
Backpack bentover rows	2-3	8-12
Inverted rows	2-3	8-12
Bicep curls	2-3	8-12
Hammer curls	2-3	8-12



Coaching Tip:

Every week aim to:

Add 1-10 lbs OR
Add 1-2 reps

That is called progressive overload
This is where growth happens.

Frequently Asked Questions:

How hard should it feel?

Aim to finish your sets thinking “I could probably do 1-2 more.” If you feel like you can do 3+ extra reps at the end of your set, you likely need to progress (add weight or reps). Don’t kill yourself, but don’t stay comfortable either.

What happens if I miss a day?

What happens when you miss a day is simple – nothing. Don’t restart the week or kill yourself to make up for the lost time. Missed Monday? Go Tuesday. Consistency over time matters so much more than having a perfect week every week.

What happens when I go on vacation?

If you're staying in a hotel, they usually have a fitness room with some basic things you can use. You'll have to modify some of your workouts, but the main point is to keep moving your body. Worst comes to worst, hop back on and start when you get back as if nothing changed.

Hopefully by now this doesn't come as a shock, but consistency really is key. Don't sweat it if you're not perfect. Nobody is.

Nutrition Made Simple

Nutrition is something people tend to make a lot harder than it should be. To put it simply, calories are a unit of measure. They measure how much and what type of energy you're putting into your body.

Your body burns a certain amount of calories every day just to stay alive. That's called your resting or basal metabolic rate (BMR).

The vast majority of people are either overeating or undereating. To find your approximate BMR, use an online calculator that will use your weight and activity level to give you an estimate of your maintenance, or the calories you need to eat in a day to neither gain nor lose weight.

Weight Loss

Eat less than you burn



Calorie Deficit



Weight Loss

Weight Gain

Eat more than you burn



Calorie Surplus



Weight Gain

Macronutrient	Job
Protein	Build
Carbohydrate	Fuel
Fat	Hormones & health

There are 3 *main types* of calories. These are your proteins, carbs, and fats. Each of them play a crucial role in your body, and it is important to keep your levels balanced. Both protein and carbs have 4 calories per gram, while fats have 9 calories per gram. This will come into play when we calculate how many of each we need.

Protein:

If there's one thing to focus on nutritionally when working out, its making sure you get enough protein. Protein is essential in the repair, formation, and maintenance of tissue in the body, including muscle.

As a rule of thumb, aim for 0.7-1 gram of protein per pound of your goal weight – not your current weight. This helps your body start adjusting to your new weight before you even obtain it.

Carbohydrates:

Carbs are not. the. enemy. So many diets include cutting out carbs almost completely, claiming that they are the reason people gain weight. Unless your body is in a state of ketosis (using fats for nergy), you need carbs to function and survive. They are your main source of energy, especially for workouts.

You do not need to cut out carbs in order to lose weight. In fact, I would highly reccommend against it.

Fats:

Most people have no idea what fats do for the body. Healthy fats are absolutely necessary for hormone health and balance and brain function. When in a calorie deficit, it is important to keep healthy fat levels high enough to keep your hormones balanced.

Now let's briefly learn how to figure out how many of each you need. For this example I'll use a person who wants to *maintain* the same weight instead of losing or gaining. If your goal is to lose or gain weight, simply add or subtract calories from your maintenance and do the calculations the same way.

In order to stay healthy while being active, it is recommended that you consume 40% of your bodyweight in grams of fat.

2,100 calories (maintenance) 140 lbs (weight)

Protein: $140 \text{ lbs} \times 1 \text{ gram per pound} = 140 \text{ grams}$

Fats: $140 \text{ lbs} \times 0.4 = 56 \text{ grams}$

Carbs: remaining calories

$140 \text{ grams protein} \times 4 \text{ cal / gram} = 560 \text{ cal}$

$56 \text{ grams fats} \times 9 \text{ cal / gram} = 504 \text{ cal}$

$2100 \text{ (total daily cals)} - 560 \text{ (protein)} - 504 \text{ (fats)} = 1,036 \text{ cal}$

$1,036 \text{ cal} \div 4 \text{ cal / gram carbs} = 259 \text{ grams carbs}$

Totals: 140 g protein, 259 g carbs, 56 g fats

Grocery List

Proteins

- Chicken
- Turkey
- Lean beef
- Eggs / Egg whites
- Greek yogurt
- Fish

Carbs

- Rice
- Potatoes
- Oats
- Fruits / Vegetables

Fats

- Avocado
- Olive oil
- Nuts
- Nut butters

Example Full Day Of Eating

Breakfast

- Greek yogurt
- Fruit
- Oats

Lunch

- Chicken
- Rice
- Vegetables

Snack

- Protein shake

Dinner

- Lean beef
- Potatoes
- Salad

Rewiring Consistency

Consistency boils down to a simple few steps. Make your habits a) simple b) repeatable and c) non-negotiable. Think of it like brushing your teeth. It's something we all do every single day without thinking, because that's just how the day goes. Make your workout an absolute non-negotiable in your day. On low motivation or low energy days, you can shorten it or make things less intense. The most important thing when you're getting into it is showing up regardless of all the other factors. Momentum will always win.

A trick to making things consistent is to try habit stacking. Habit stacking is the practice of 'stacking' a new habit to one that you already do consistently. For example, always go to the gym right after work before you go home. You will always go to work, so if you attach the gym to work, it makes it easier to stay consistent.

Habit Stacking Worksheet

Current Habit:

New Habit:

I will stack:

Onto my habit of:

A final note I have on consistency is the importance of setting realistic expectations and celebrating your small wins. Something I like to tell clients is “try to be 1% better every day”. You are never going to wake up and be 100% better than you were yesterday. Progress takes time.

Every time you see progress, let yourself know how proud you are of yourself. Tell yourself good job. Allow yourself to celebrate. The finish line does not always have to move. Think of it as many small finish lines and make sure to focus on the one you're currently heading towards.

Relying on motivation is a surefire way to become inconsistent. Make your healthy habits simple, repeatable, and non-negotiable and you'll find that you're able to completely rewire how your brain thinks about health.

How to Track Your Progress

Progress is never linear. So how do you actually track it?

The scale

While the scale is a tool – a very powerful tool – it is still just a tool. Your weight can fluctuate daily due to plenty of things like water retention, sodium intake, stress, sleep, hormones, etc. You should focus on trends over time. If you remain consistent for a month, how did the scale move?

Off-the-scale

While the scale is a huge factor in a lot of peoples fitness journeys, there are tons of other ways to measure your progress. My top three include progress photos, clothing size changes, and strength increases.

Try taking photos of your physique every 2-4 weeks so you can monitor any changes.

Your clothes may start to fit different as well. Maybe a shirt you've been wearing for the last 2 years all the sudden becomes too big or too small. That's another surefire way to determine that the workouts are changing your physique.

Lastly, strength increases. As a newbie, you'll likely see a drastic amount of change in your strength at the beginning. While this strength gain will taper off a bit as you settle into working out, tracking your weights over time is a good indicator on if progress is being made. Try to keep track of the weights you use for each exercise, and compare them every month or so.

Real progress is something that takes time and is often less dramatic than people anticipate. One crunch won't give you abs, unfortunately.

Progress Tracker

Monthly check in

Weight:

Energy levels: __/10

Confidence: __/10

Did my lifts go up in weight? Yes/No

Did I take my progress photo? Yes/No

Frequently Asked Questions

1. **What supplements should I take?**

Supplements are exactly as the name suggests, to *supplement* work that's already in progress. As you start out, I recommend utilizing clean protein powders, creatine monohydrate (only if you are very good at hydration), and a basic multivitamin. That's it. Focus on training consistently, sleeping well, and eating right.

2. **What happens if I don't see results?**

Don't panic. Like we talked about, progress takes a lot of time and consistency. Before freaking out and switching things up, ask yourself: Have I actually been consistent for 6-8 weeks? Have I been hitting my nutrition goals? Am I making an effort to be active outside of the gym?

Don't quit just because it's not obvious yet.

3. Can I still go out or can I still drink?

Yes. You absolutely do not and should not give up your social life for your fitness journey. That being said, it is important to be mindful in these occasions. Alcohol has calories, it affects sleep, recovery, and hunger cues. As long as you are aware of these and account for them within your plan, you have no reason to need to give up a fun night out.

4. How much cardio do I need?

Probably less than you think.

Cardio is great and absolutely necessary in programs due to its impact on overall health. It is an important tool in burning extra calories, improving endurance, and increasing daily energy expenditure.

That all being said, you do not need hours on the treadmill in order to lose weight. A simple goal like 7,000-10,000 steps a day or 2-4 cardio sessions per week is likely all you need when you're just starting out.

5. Should I be sore after every workout?

This is a great question and one I get asked often. The short answer – Maybe. Soreness is caused by microscopic tears in the muscle. For that reason, it is not uncommon to feel sore after trying new exercises, but also not uncommon to not experience soreness from a motion you've done before.

The bottom line here is that every body is different and every body will react differently to exercise. You may find that you're sore after every single workout, or none of them no matter how hard you push.

Focus on progressive overload and consistency over time rather than chasing the feeling of being sore.

6. Will woman get bulky?

The idea of women getting bulky has scared so many girls away from the gym for so long. The difference between the bad 'bulky' and the ideal 'toned' is the underlying fat. You need to lift heavy if you ever want to be able to grow enough muscle to achieve a 'toned' look. You will just need to shed the excess fat. So the short answer- No.

7. Should I workout fasted?

The only form of exercise that should be done on an empty stomach is steady state cardio. If you are doing any other form of exercise like lifting, running, pilates, etc. You need to fuel your body accordingly by eating beforehand.

The Action Plan

Before you leave this guide and go on to start your journey, I want to leave you with the basics.

Pick a workout plan.

Stop searching for the 'perfect' split for your body. Fully commit yourself to whatever plan you pick for the next few months. You will be shocked by the amount you will learn in those first few months. Allow yourself enough time to adapt and change before bailing on a plan.

Get your ass in the gym.

At some point you have to stop just thinking and start doing. Think about where you could be today if you started a year ago. Don't let that be you this time next year. Even if confidence isn't there. Even if your workouts aren't perfect.

Eat well.

Get enough protein. Eat foods that come from the earth. Fuel your body in a way that shows it how much you appreciate it. Your body needs food to survive. Act like it.

Move daily.

This is the most overlooked aspect of fitness and arguably one of the most important. Be active outside of the gym. Working out is great, but make sure you don't sit around the rest of the day. Start with small walks everyday and go from there.

Stop starting over.

One bad weekend or one bad week does not ruin your progress. Fitness is not about being perfect, it never has been. It's about returning and putting yourself first even when it's hard.

Rinse. Wash. Repeat.

30 Day Challenge

For the next 30 days:

- ☐ Follow your workout plan religiously
- ☐ 7-10k steps daily
- ☐ Hit your protein goal
- ☐ Drink 64+ oz water
- ☐ Don't start over

About the author

My story:

I fell in love with lifting in highschool when I decided to kick for the football team. That meant lifting sessions with 60 boys. While it was intimidating as all get out, I quickly became addicted.

After that I was obsessed. It played a huge factor in my decision to major in Biology in college, as well as led me to my first job post grad and where I currently am now as a personal trainer.

I am a huge believer in the fact that everyone needs guidance when it comes to starting their fitness journey, but I also believe that it shouldn't cost a grand to get started. Some people just need a gentle hand to guide.

What's Next?

If you've finished this guide, congratulations, It's finally time to lock in and get after it.

Free Resources

Instagram: @allisehelses

Need More Help?

My 1:1 Coaching Includes:

- Custom workouts
- Nutrition guidance
- Accountability
- Weekly support

If you're still feeling overwhelmed, or think a more hands on approach would be better for you, DM me "GUIDE" on Insta and we can chat about coaching.